signalmash

Concert and Festival Marketing: Selling Out Through Verified Messaging

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Executive Summary

Your event announcement gets lost in Instagram feeds within 30 seconds. Your presale email sits unopened in spam folders. Your fans miss early access opportunities because push notifications don't break through the noise. Meanwhile, scalpers and bots snap up tickets meant for real fans.

The entertainment industry has a messaging problem where event promoters spend millions building hype only to watch critical communications fail at the moment that matters most during ticket sales. Fans want to buy tickets but never see the announcement, want presale access but miss the registration window, and are excited about lineup additions but don't find out until it's too late.

Rich Communication Services (RCS) changes how entertainment companies communicate with fans in the United States. This isn't another social media platform fighting for attention or another email that gets filtered but verified, direct messaging that reaches fans on the device that's always in their hand with interactive content that drives immediate action.

This whitepaper examines how RCS enables presale campaigns that actually reach interested fans, artist announcements that generate measurable excitement, lineup delivery that keeps audiences engaged, and ticket sales workflows that convert interest into purchases at rates traditional channels can't match.

The Broken Model of Event Marketing

You post your major festival announcement on Instagram and the algorithm shows it to **3%** of your followers. Organic reach on social platforms has collapsed, and unless you're paying for promoted posts, most of your audience never sees your content.

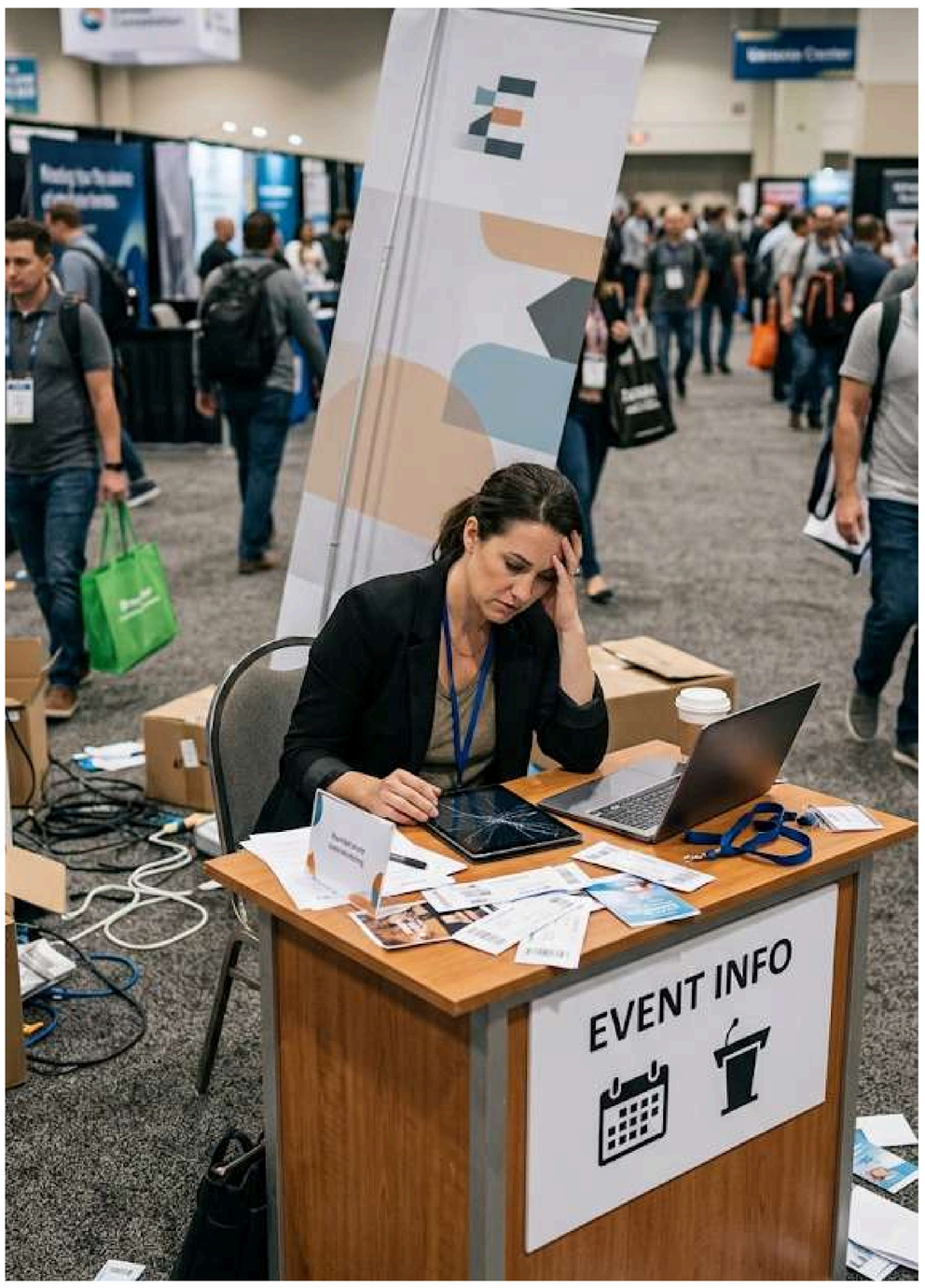
Even when fans do see your posts, there's no guarantee they'll remember the on-sale date, presale code, or venue information because social media is a scrolling experience where content appears, gets consumed in a glance, and disappears into the feed with no persistent reference or saved information.

Event announcement emails have open rates around **15-20%** on average, meaning **80%** of your mailing list never even sees your message. Of those who do open, many don't read carefully enough to note sale dates, presale codes, or venue details.

Timing makes this worse because fans check email sporadically where your announcement arrives at **10 AM** Tuesday but they don't check email until Wednesday evening when your message is buried under dozens of other emails with the excitement gone and urgency faded.

Spam filters are getting more aggressive where legitimate event announcements often get flagged because they contain typical spam trigger words like

"exclusive offer," "limited time," and "act now."



Mobile apps can send push notifications, but fans have to download your app first, and for all but the biggest promoters and venues, app downloads are minimal. Casual fans won't install an app for one concert, and even dedicated fans delete apps after events to free up phone storage.

Generic push notifications from downloaded apps get dismissed without reading because phones are buzzing constantly and most people swipe away notifications reflexively without processing the content.

When legitimate fans do see your announcements and try to buy tickets, they're competing with bots and scalpers who have automated systems monitoring for on-sale moments.

By the time real fans navigate to the ticket page, inventory is already depleted. The current model rewards the most automated, most aggressive buyers rather than the most passionate fans, which isn't just frustrating but actively damaging to your brand when real fans can't get tickets to shows they desperately want to attend.

Understanding RCS for Entertainment Marketing

RCS comes in two formats, each serving different communication needs for entertainment and event marketing. RCS Basic provides verified text messages with brand trust including your logo and verified badge, giving fans confidence they're communicating with your official organization.

Character limits are **160 characters** per message using standard text or **70** characters if using emojis or special characters, with messages automatically including URL preview generation and read receipt support.

If a fan's device doesn't support RCS, messages automatically fall back to SMS. RCS Basic works perfectly for time-sensitive alerts including ticket sale notifications, presale code delivery, on-sale reminders, gate change alerts, and critical event updates, with implementation taking **1-2 days.**

RCS Multimedia provides rich, interactive messaging experiences where character limits expand to **8,000+** characters per message. You can send rich cards with images and video, create carousels with up to **10 cards**, include up to 4 action buttons per card, and integrate webviews for complex interactions.

The drag-and-drop campaign builder makes creating sophisticated message flows straightforward, while the advanced analytics dashboard tracks performance across all campaigns.

RCS Multimedia excels for marketing campaigns including artist announcements with visual content, lineup reveals with interactive elements, presale registration workflows, personalized schedule building, and post-event engagement, with implementation taking **2-5 days**.

The verified sender badge is critical for entertainment marketing because ticket scams cost fans millions annually where scammers create fake accounts pretending to be official event promoters, sending fraudulent purchase links or collecting payment for nonexistent tickets.

RCS verified sender status eliminates this risk because when fans receive RCS messages from your event, they see your official verified badge and brand logo with no question about message authenticity.

The carrier verifies your identity and displays your verified brand information with every message, and this verification process is rigorous and cannot be faked or spoofed by scammers.

One of RCS's most valuable features for event marketing is delivery and read receipt confirmation.

Unlike email where you can only guess at open rates, RCS tells you definitively when messages are delivered and when recipients read them.

This data transforms campaign optimization where you know exactly which messages performed well and which didn't resonate, can track read rates by time of day to identify optimal send times for your specific audience, and understand which subject lines or preview text drove the highest engagement.

Presale and Early Access Campaigns

Traditional presale registration is a mess where fans submit their email address on a website, receive a confirmation email they may or may not see, and hope they remember the presale date and code when the time comes.

RCS presale registration is different where a fan texts **"PRESALE"** to your short code or taps a registration link in your initial announcement message. Using RCS Basic, confirmation arrives immediately showing your verified brand, the presale date and time, and the access code, with the fan saving this message in their thread giving them permanent access to the information.

For more complex registration, RCS Multimedia handles multi-step workflows where the fan receives a rich card with event imagery, taps "**Register for Presale,**" answers a few quick questions through suggested reply buttons, and receives comprehensive confirmation with all details saved as an interactive card they can reference anytime.

Two days before presale, a reminder message arrives automatically via RCS Basic stating "Your presale for Summer Music Festival starts Thursday at **10 AM**.

Your access code: **SUMMER2026**" with the message including a URL to the ticket purchase page with preview generation showing the event information.

The morning of presale, another RCS Basic message arrives stating "Presale starts in **30 minutes**. Your code: **SUMMER2026**. Purchase link opens at **10 AM**" where the fan is primed, ready, and has all the information they need immediately accessible in their message thread.



Verified fan programs attempt to give real fans priority over scalpers, but implementation through email is clunky. RCS Multimedia makes verified fan programs straightforward where registration happens through conversational messaging with rich cards and action buttons asking "**Are you a fan of [Artist Name]?**" with the fan tapping "**Yes**" or "**No**," followed by "How many times have you seen them live?" with quick reply buttons showing "**Never**," "**1-2 times**," "**3-5 times**," "**6+ times**," and "**Which album is your favorite?**" with a carousel showing album covers for easy selection. Survey completion takes **30** seconds instead of several minutes, with the interactive format being engaging rather than tedious.



Many events offer multiple presale tiers including fan club presale, credit card presale, general presale, and public on-sale.

RCS handles tiered access elegantly through segmented messaging where each fan receives messages relevant to their access level only.

Fan club members get an RCS Multimedia message with exclusive branding stating "Your exclusive presale starts Monday at 10 AM.

As a fan club member, you get first access" with the rich card showing the event with special "**Fan Club Exclusive**" treatment. Credit card holders get their own message stating "Your presale starts Tuesday at **10** AM.

Use your [Card Brand] card for access" with the message including card-specific branding and benefits. General presale subscribers receive "Your presale starts Wednesday at 10 AM. Register now for access code."

Tours announcing multiple cities face a challenge about how to communicate effectively with fans in different markets without overwhelming everyone with information about shows they can't attend.

RCS enables location-based messaging through subscriber data where a fan in Chicago gets an RCS Multimedia message stating "**Summer tour coming to Chicago. United Center on July 15**" with the rich card showing the venue, date, and purchase button, while a fan in Los Angeles gets the same campaign structure customized for their market.

Fans can indicate interest in multiple cities if they're willing to travel using RCS Multimedia action buttons asking "**Interested in other tour dates? Select cities**" where the fan taps buttons for Dallas, Austin, and Houston and receives targeted presale information for all four markets through subsequent messages.

Artist Announcements and Lineup Delivery

Major artist announcements benefit from building anticipation rather than just dropping the news, and RCS enables teaser campaigns that engage fans and create buzz. An RCS Basic message with verified branding arrives stating "**Something big coming Monday. Want to be the first to know? Reply YES**" where fans who reply get added to the announcement list.

simple interaction creates commitment because the fan has expressed interest and is now watching for your message.

Follow-up teasers increase excitement using RCS Basic for time-sensitive updates like "**48 hours until we announce the headliner**" and "Tomorrow at noon, you'll find out who's headlining" with each message maintaining the verified sender badge that confirms authenticity.

When the announcement drops, fans who engaged with teasers receive it immediately via RCS Multimedia where a rich card displays the artist image, event logo, dates, and venue with action buttons providing options for "**Buy Tickets**," "**Share with Friends**," and "**Set Reminder.**"

The visual impact and immediate call-to-action drive higher engagement than text-only announcements, creating a sense of exclusivity where fans who engaged with the campaign feel like insiders getting special access rather than just another audience member seeing a generic social post.

When announcing a headliner via RCS Multimedia, messages include more than just the name where a rich card shows the artist photo and event details with an action button for "**Watch Exclusive Message.**" Tapping opens a webview with a **30-second** video of the artist talking about the performance they're planning, what fans can expect, or why they're excited about this particular festival.

This content is exclusive to RCS recipients and not posted on social media or uploaded to YouTube, with fans receiving something special because they subscribed to your RCS communications. This reinforces the value of staying subscribed and increases long-term engagement.

Festival lineup announcements generate massive excitement, but delivering lineup information effectively through traditional channels is difficult.

RCS Multimedia lineup announcements are interactive where the initial message shows the lineup poster as a rich card image with action buttons below providing options for "**View Full Lineup**," "Top Artists," and "**By Genre.**" Tapping "View Full Lineup" opens a carousel with rich cards for each major artist where each card includes artist photo, genre tags, and buttons for "**Listen on Spotify,**" "**Watch on YouTube,**" and "Save to My Schedule."

Festival schedules are complex with multiple stages, dozens of artists, and overlapping performance times. RCS Multimedia enables personalized schedule building that stays accessible throughout the event where "Build your festival schedule" arrives as a rich card with the action button opening a webview showing the full lineup.

Fans tap heart icons next to artists they want to see, and the system automatically flags time conflicts asking

"You selected two artists performing at the same time: [Artist A] and [Artist B]. Which would you prefer?"

The fan makes choices, and their conflict-free schedule generates automatically. The completed personal schedule arrives as a series of rich cards in the message thread where each card represents a day of the festival showing performance times chronologically with stage locations.

Weather, technical issues, and logistics create inevitable schedule changes at live events, and RCS Basic enables instant, targeted notifications to specific audience segments. A performance moves from outdoor main stage to indoor secondary stage due to rain, and fans who saved that artist in their schedule receive "[Artist Name] moved to West Hall stage due to weather.

Performance still at 9 PM. Tap for venue map" with the URL preview showing a map of the venue with the new stage highlighted. Only affected fans receive the notification where attendees who weren't planning to see that artist don't get interrupted with irrelevant information.



Ticket Sales and Conversion

Every additional step between interest and purchase reduces conversion, and traditional ticket sales require fans to see an announcement, remember the on-sale time, navigate to a ticketing website, create an account or log in, search for the event, select tickets, and complete checkout.

RCS removes most of these steps where the ticket announcement message via RCS Multimedia includes a rich card with event image, date, venue, and an action button for "***Buy Tickets Now***."

The fan taps the button and lands on the event ticket selection page, and for presale events, the access code is embedded in the purchase URL parameters where the code applies automatically when the fan arrives at the ticketing site.

This direct path increases conversion rates by **40-60%** compared to announcements that require fans to navigate to ticket sites independently.

Even with reduced friction, some fans add tickets to cart and abandon purchase before completing checkout, and RCS Basic cart abandonment recovery is immediate.

The fan adds tickets to cart but doesn't complete purchase, and five minutes later receives "Still want [Event] tickets? Complete purchase: [URL]" where the message is concise, urgent, and actionable.

The URL links directly back to their cart with tickets still selected where one tap and they're back at checkout.



This immediate intervention recovers **25-30%** of abandoned carts that would otherwise be lost sales.

Sold out shows still represent sales opportunities through released tickets, production holds returning to inventory, and last-minute cancellations creating intermittent availability after initial sellout.

RCS waitlist management works through both message types where when fans try to purchase sold out tickets, they receive an RCS Multimedia message with a rich card showing the event with "**SOLD OUT**" overlay and text stating "This event is sold out.

Join the waitlist to be notified if tickets become available." The action button says "Join Waitlist" where the fan taps and receives immediate confirmation via RCS Basic stating "You're on the waitlist for [Event]. We'll text immediately if tickets become available."

Festivals and concerts are social experiences where many fans attend with friends, family, or partners, and RCS facilitates group sales in ways email and social media cannot.

RCS Multimedia enables group offers stating "**Going with friends? 4 tickets for the price of 3**" with the rich card showing the offer details with action buttons for "Buy for My Group" and "Share This Offer."

Tapping "**Share This Offer**" provides a unique URL the fan can share through any messaging app where when someone clicks the link and completes purchase, the group discount applies automatically.

Event Day Experience and Post-Event Engagement

Event day entry creates bottlenecks where lines form at gates as staff scan tickets, check IDs, and process entry, and RCS enables faster, more efficient entry processes.

The morning of the event, fans receive an RCS Multimedia message stating "Today's the day! Your mobile ticket is ready" with a rich card displaying the event with an embedded barcode optimized for scanning and action buttons showing "View Full Ticket Details" and "Get Directions to Venue."

The ticket barcode displays directly in the RCS message where there's no need to open an app, find the right screen, or adjust brightness.



Once inside the venue, fans need information about restroom locations, food vendors, merchandise booths, first aid stations, and ride-share pickup zones, and RCS provides this information on-demand.

Fans text keywords to your event number where a fan texts "**RESTROOMS**" and receives an RCS Multimedia rich card showing a venue map with the three nearest restroom locations highlighted, or a fan texts "**FOOD**" and receives a carousel showing food vendor options with cuisine types and locations.

Large events require robust emergency communication systems, and RCS enables direct, immediate safety communication. Severe weather approaching triggers mass RCS Basic messages to all attendees stating "Severe weather alert.

Move to indoor shelter areas immediately. Nearest: West Hall entrance" where the message is concise, urgent, and actionable within the **160-character** limit. For more detailed emergency instructions, RCS Multimedia sends rich cards with maps, visual directions, and action buttons for additional information.

The event ends but the experience continues where post-event communication keeps fans engaged and builds anticipation for future events.

The day after the event, an RCS Multimedia message arrives stating "Thanks for attending [Event]! Relive the experience" with a rich card showing event highlights with action buttons for "**View Photo Gallery**," "**Watch Performance Videos,**" and "**See Full Setlists**." Each button opens a webview with the requested content where fans browse official photos, tag themselves, and share with friends.

Repeat attendees are more valuable than one-time customers, and RCS enables loyalty programs that reward frequent fans and drive repeat purchases.

After a fan's third event attendance, an RCS Multimedia message arrives stating "You've attended 3 events this year. You've earned Gold status" with the rich card showing their status tier with benefits including priority presale access, 10% merchandise discount, and exclusive content.

Points systems work through RCS messaging where after each event, an RCS Basic message confirms points earned stating "You earned 100 points for attending [Event]. Total balance: **450** points. Text REWARDS to view options."

The best time to sell tickets to the next event is right after someone attended your current event when their excitement is highest and their willingness to commit is greatest.

Two days after an event, an RCS Multimedia message plants seeds for future purchases stating "Had fun? [Next Event] dates just announced: July 21-23" with the rich card showing the next event with early bird ticket information and action buttons displaying "Buy Early Bird Tickets" and "Learn More."

Measuring Success and Implementation

Traditional email for event announcements averages 15-20% open rate compared to RCS messages for event announcements achieving 95-98% delivery and read rate.

The difference is stark where when you send an RCS message about your event, you can be confident nearly everyone receives and reads it with read receipts providing actual confirmation rather than estimated open rates.

Email ticket sale announcements generate 1-3% click-through to ticket purchase pages compared to RCS ticket sale announcements generating 18-25% click-through to ticket purchase pages.



The dramatic difference comes from higher visibility where more people see the message initially, verified sender trust reducing skepticism about clicking links, perfect timing hitting fans when they're most likely to take action, and direct action buttons in RCS Multimedia messages making clicking effortless.

Conversion from click to purchase is higher through RCS as well where fans who click through from RCS messages convert at **35-40%** compared to **20-25%** from email. The cumulative effect means RCS drives **8-10x** more ticket sales per message sent.

For a **10,000**-capacity event, an email announcement might generate 200 clicks and **40-50** ticket sales while the same announcement via RCS generates 2,000 clicks and **700-800** ticket sales, with the impact on box office revenue being substantial.

Traditional digital marketing for event ticket sales costs **$15-30** per ticket sold when factoring in advertising spend, email marketing platform costs, and social media promotion.

RCS messaging costs **$0.01-0.03** per message for RCS Basic delivery and **$0.03-0.08** per message for RCS Multimedia rich cards. For fans who already opted in to your RCS communications, customer acquisition cost approaches zero where the ticket sales happen through messages that cost pennies to deliver.

Even including the cost of acquiring RCS subscribers through advertising and promotions, the overall customer acquisition cost runs **60-70%** lower than traditional digital marketing approaches.

Start with a single event or small festival to test RCS implementation, allowing you to learn platform capabilities, train staff, and identify issues before company-wide deployment. Begin with RCS Basic for transactional messages where ticket purchase confirmations, presale code delivery, and event reminders are perfect starting points.

Build your RCS subscriber list through existing channels by adding opt-in prompts to your website, email signatures, and social media profiles stating "Get event updates via text. Text JOIN to [short code]."

After successful testing, expand RCS to all events and festivals where the platform infrastructure is in place and workflows are proven. Integrate RCS opt-in into your standard ticket purchase flow where at checkout completion, you present "Get event updates and exclusive offers via text? [Phone number field] By providing your number, you agree to receive RCS messages." This rapidly grows your subscriber base with highly engaged fans who just purchased tickets.

Conclusion

Event marketing has a reach problem where the best artist lineup, the most compelling festival experience, and the most competitive ticket prices don't matter if your target audience never sees your announcements.

RCS solves the reach problem while simultaneously solving the conversion problem through messages that get delivered and read at rates traditional channels can't match, fans engaging with interactive content that makes ticket purchases easy and immediate, and verified sender status building trust and preventing fraud.

The numbers speak clearly with higher delivery rates, higher read rates, higher click-through rates, higher conversion rates, lower customer acquisition costs, and greater lifetime value where RCS outperforms email and social media across every meaningful metric.

Your competitors are exploring RCS now, and early movers gain significant advantages including larger subscriber bases, more platform expertise, and stronger fan relationships built through superior communication.

The fans are ready because they want direct communication from event promoters and artists they care about, want announcements that don't get buried in social feeds or spam folders, and want easy ticket purchases without navigation friction.

RCS delivers what fans want while driving the business outcomes you need. The question isn't whether entertainment companies will adopt RCS for event marketing but whether you'll lead this shift or follow competitors who acted sooner.

RCS Studio provides the platform entertainment companies need to implement verified messaging at scale. Our solution handles the technical complexity while providing event-specific workflows, fraud prevention through verified sender badges, and the tools needed for sophisticated marketing campaigns.

We work with promoters, venues, and entertainment companies to build RCS communication strategies that fill seats and create exceptional fan experiences.

The future of event marketing is direct, verified, and interactive. Give your fans the communication experience they deserve while selling more tickets than ever before.

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